

8.2 The Vision

In July 2005, *Digit* carried an article on the Gadget of Our Dreams (aka GOD), in which we played soothsayer and tried to predict what the gadget of the near future would look like. We focused on shrinking the laptop or tablet PC to a more pocketable size—the size of a standard PDA today. However, though a lot of people feel that the mobile phone is set to become the master of all trades, there will perhaps always be a market for no-nonsense devices that focus on just getting a specific task done.

With the mobile phone, the trend is shifting towards convergence. Yet, it's quite possible that certain products will be made just to handle the tasks of a cell phone. Cell phones cannot shrink to minuscule sizes because of the current demands: a digital camera, MP3 player, video player, PIM applications, and more, all in one device—oh, and let's not forget the ability to send and receive calls and SMSes! Let's take a look at some pictures of devices that are already under development, are in the prototype stage, being marketed, or just simply visualised:

OK, the image on the right *is not* a real phone: it's a mock model made to make fun of the main character in the movie *Zoolander*. But even then, actually owning something like this would be really cool! Current technology is capable of developing such a device, but you would be ruining your eyesight trying to read the screen, even with a single line display!

Toshiba's 0.85 inch hard drive is made with mobile phones in mind. With capacities of up to 4 GB already shipping, it's easy to see why mobile devices will shrink in the near future. This artist's impression, courtesy Canesta (www.canesta.com), a company working on projection keyboards, gives us the impression that not just displays but even keyboards can be simulated, and thus removed from the actual device! On the right is NEC's thoughts of the future, already incorporating projected displays as well as a projected input keyboard.